PLAYING WITH FIRE

THE POLITICS OF FAITH THE BJP AND THE TMC ARE PRACTISING IN BENGAL IN THE RUN-UP TO THE 2026 POLLS BODES ILL FOR ITS COMMUNAL FABRIC. THE VIOLENCE IN MURSHIDABAD OVER THE WAQF LAW IS JUST A TRAILER

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar



ANI

Nowhere did the ripples of discontent over the recently passed Waqf Amendment Act spread as viciously as they did in West Bengal. The unrest was particularly intense in the Muslim-majority districts of Murshidabad and Malda, as well as in Bhangor, in South 24 Parganas. What began as simple protests soon escalated into a violent conflagration on April 11–12, once again exposing the deep communal fault lines that run through the state. Three people died, more than 200 arrests were made, and paramilitary forces were deployed. The crisis is a grim reminder of Bengal's shifting political landscape, where the two leading parties—the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the main Opposition Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—are striving to outdo each other in their bid to corner the Hindu vote, creating discontent among the state's large Muslim population, a year before the 2026 assembly election.

The initial spark in Murshidabad was lit in Dhuliyan, in Samserganj block, on April 11. Protesters torched police vehicles and clashed with security forces. In nearby Suti, Ejaz Ahmed was allegedly shot dead by the police. Just a few kilometres away in Samserganj, Hargobindo Das, 70, and his son Chandan, 40, were killed in their own home. The police arrived four hours later. Ironically, the very next day, the police allowed a Ramnavami procession to pass through the area. Some of the marchers allegedly made incendiary speeches; an organiser has since been arrested. On April 15, the police arrested two persons in connection with the murders.

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has publicly rejected the implementation of the amended Waqf law in Bengal. "Dharma means devotion, affection, humanity, peace, culture, harmony, and unity," she declared in



"DHARMA MEANS DEVOTION, PEACE, AMITY, CULTURE HUMANITY AND HARMONY.... WHY THE FIGHT? WHY RIOTS, WAR OR UNREST?"

MAMATA BANERJEE
Chief Minister, West Bengal; Founder chairperson, TMC